

AQUACULTURE AND AFRICA'S GROWING DEMAND FOR FISH

Africa's Growing Demand for Fish

Rapid population growth, urbanisation and changing diets are increasing Africa's demand for fish and other aquatic foods, while many wild fish stocks face growing pressure.

Africa produces less than 2.5% of global aquaculture output, highlighting both its current production gap and significant potential for growth. By 2050, Africa may need approximately 74% more aquatic animal food simply to maintain its 2022 per-capita consumption level.

Sustainable aquaculture can help close the supply gap, but it must develop alongside responsible management of capture fisheries.

What is Aquaculture?

Aquaculture is the farming of fish, shellfish, aquatic plants and other aquatic organisms in freshwater, brackish-water or marine environments. Unlike capture fisheries, which harvest naturally occurring wild stocks, aquaculture involves actively managing production through breeding, stocking, feeding, health management and harvesting.

In 2024, aquaculture produced a record 103 million tonnes of aquatic animals, representing 53% of global aquatic animal production.

For Africa, sustainable aquaculture can increase the supply of affordable and nutritious fish, create employment, support local economies, reduce dependence on imports and complement sustainably managed capture fisheries.

Aquaculture Will Thrive When Done Sustainably

Aquaculture is not automatically environmentally sustainable. Poorly planned operations can pollute water, damage sensitive habitats, spread disease, introduce invasive species and increase competition for land and water. Responsible growth requires careful site selection, quality seed and feed, effective disease prevention, good water and waste management, climate-risk planning and strong environmental regulation.

The sector must also overcome limited access to finance, expensive inputs, weak extension services, unreliable energy, inadequate cold-chain infrastructure and insufficient technical knowledge.

Five Priorities for Africa's Aquaculture Sector

1. Research, innovation and reliable data
2. Quality seed, affordable feed and finance
3. Training, extension and aquatic animal health
4. Environmental, biosecurity and food-safety standards
5. Inclusive and climate-resilient value chains

Opportunities for Advancing Aquaculture in Africa

Africa's extensive rivers, lakes, reservoirs, floodplains and coastal areas provide opportunities for freshwater and marine aquaculture. Commonly farmed species include tilapia, African catfish and African bonytongue, with additional potential for shellfish, seaweed and other locally suitable species.

Opportunities for Women and Youth

Aquaculture can create employment and enterprise opportunities for women and young people in production, processing, value addition, marketing, research, extension and innovation. However, inclusion must be deliberate. Women and youth need equitable access to finance, land, water, technology, training, inputs, markets and decision-making. Their participation should extend to ownership, leadership and the more profitable parts of the value chain.

WASMaN calls on governments, researchers, producers, investors, communities and development partners to support a productive, inclusive, climate-resilient and environmentally responsible aquaculture sector in Africa.